The Haunted Map

The European Folklore Behind Familiar Halloween Costumes

The tradition of Halloween costumes dates back over 2,000 years to the ancient Celtic festival of Samhain, celebrated in parts of what are now Ireland, Scotland, and Britain. Samhain marked the end of the harvest and the beginning of winter, a season associated with death and darkness. Celts believed that on the night of October 31, the veil between the living and the dead thinned, allowing spirits to roam the earth. To protect themselves or confuse these souls, people wore disguises made from animal skins and heads, blending in with the supernatural or attempting to ward them off.

As Christianity spread through Europe, many pagan customs merged with Christian holidays. Samhain became linked to All Hallows' Eve, the night before All Saints' Day. In the Middle Ages, people practiced "souling," where the poor went door to door offering prayers for the dead in exchange for food. Participants often wore masks or costumes, both as a spiritual gesture and as a way to hide from evil spirits. These early disguises helped shape the beginnings of Halloween costume traditions as we know them today.

Excerpted from Dressed to Disturb: A Haunted History of Halloween Costumes, by Ashley Chan

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1. The Dullahan



Also known as the Headless Horseman, the Dullahan appears as a mounted horseman or a coachman driving a horse-drawn carriage out of graveyards, and arrives at the doorstep of a person whose death is approaching

2. Sir Fulke Greville



Sir Fulke Greville took possession of Warwick Castle in 1604, was murdered by one of his servants in London, and his body was brought back to the Castle, where there have been numerous sightings of his misty form roaming the halls

3. Witches



The Witch Trials of Trier took place between 1581 and 1593, and led to the death of 368 people, all of whom were executed for practicing witchcraft, magic, or sorcery.

4. Frankenstein



Frankenstein Castle overlooks the city of Darmstadt, Germany, and may have been an inspiration for Mary Shelley when she wrote her 1818 Gothic novel Frankenstein; or, The Modern Prometheus

5. Werewolves



Belief in werewolves developed parallel to the belief in European witches, in the course of the Late Middle Ages and the Early Modern period. Like the witchcraft trials as a whole, the trial of supposed werewolves emerged in Valais in what is now Switzerland in the early 15th century

6. Krampus

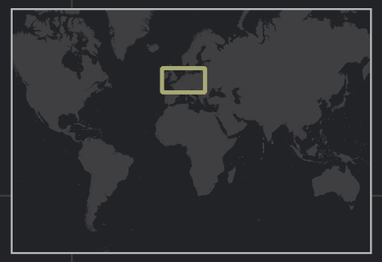


The Krampus is a horned figure from the Alpine folkloric tradition who accompanies St Nicholas on December 6--St Nick rewards the well-behaved children with gifts, and Krampus punishes the badly behaved ones by beating them with birch branches

7. Vlad Dracula



Stories about Vlad Dracula (also known as Vlad the Impaler) made him the best-known medieval ruler of the Romanian lands in Europe, but Bram Stoker's 1897 novel Dracula was the first book to make a connection between Dracula and vampirism



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